

PŪRVA-MĪMĀṂSĀ

Comprehensive Study Notes

Based on Chapter 13 of C. D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*

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I. Introduction

The word *Mīmāṃsā* literally means 'revered thought'. It was originally applied to the interpretation of the Vedic rituals which commanded the highest reverence; the word is now used more broadly for any critical investigation. The school of Mīmāṃsā justifies **both** senses: it supplies rules according to which the commandments of the Veda are to be interpreted, *and* it gives a philosophical justification for Vedic ritualism.

Just as Sāṅkhya and Yoga, and Vaiśeṣika and Nyāya, are regarded as allied systems, similarly Mīmāṃsā and Vedānta are treated as allied systems of thought. Both are based on, and both try to interpret, the Veda.

The Two Divisions of the Veda and the Two Mīmāṃsās

- The earlier portion of the Veda — the Mantra and the Brāhmaṇa portions — is called **Karmakāṇḍa**.
- The later portion — the Upaniṣads — is called **Jñānakāṇḍa**, because the former deals with action, rituals and sacrifices, while the latter deals with the knowledge of reality.
- Mīmāṃsā deals with the earlier portion and is therefore called **Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā**, also **Karma-Mīmāṃsā**.

- Vedānta deals with the later portion and is therefore called **Uttara-Mīmāṃsā**, also **Jñāna-Mīmāṃsā**.
- The former deals with *Dharma* and is hence also called **Dharma-Mīmāṃsā**; the latter deals with *Brahman* and is hence also called **Brahma-Mīmāṃsā**.

The Pre-Śaṅkarite Karma-Jñāna-Samuchchaya-vāda

There has been a long line of pre-Śaṅkarite teachers of Vedānta — of whom Maṇḍana Miśra seems to be the last — who regarded Mīmāṃsā and Vedānta as forming a **single system**, and who advocated the combination of action and knowledge, known as **Karma-Jñāna-samuchchaya-vāda**. According to them the sūtras, beginning with the first sūtra of Jaimini and ending with the last sūtra of Bādarāyaṇa, form one compact śāstra. These teachers held that Karma (action) and Upāsanā (meditation) were absolutely essential to hasten the dawn of true knowledge.

Even the great Śaṅkarāchārya — who treated action and knowledge as absolutely opposed, like darkness and light, and who relegated Karma to the sphere of Avidyā — had to admit that Karma and Upāsanā do purify the soul, though they are not the direct cause of liberation. It is on this ground that the study of Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā, though not essential for the study of Vedānta, was regarded as a good means for the purification of the soul.

Kumārila Bhaṭṭa himself may rightly be regarded as the link between the Pūrva and the Uttara Mīmāṃsā. Rāmānuja and Bhāskara believe that the Pūrva and Uttara Mīmāṃsās together form **one science**, the study of the former being necessary before undertaking the study of the latter. Madhva and Vallabha, though they make devotion to God a necessary prerequisite for the study of Vedānta, nevertheless believe that Vedānta is a *continuation* of Mīmāṃsā.

Character of Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā as a System

- Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā regards the Veda as **eternal and authorless**, and of infallible authority.
- It is essentially a book of ritual, dealing with commandments prescribing injunctions or prohibitions.
- Greatest importance is attached to the **Brāhmaṇa** portion of the Veda, to which both the Mantras and the Upaniṣads are subordinated.
- The aim of Mīmāṃsā is to supply the principles according to which Vedic texts are to be interpreted, and to provide philosophical justification for the views contained therein.
- The work of finding interpretive principles was undertaken first by the Brāhmaṇas themselves, and mainly by the Śrauta-sūtras; Mīmāṃsā continues this work.

But had it done only that, Mīmāṃsā would have been, at best, only a commentary on the Vedic ritual. What entitles it to the rank of a **philosophical system** is its keen desire to provide philosophical justification for the Vedic views, and to replace the earlier ideal of the attainment of heaven (*svarga*) by the ideal of obtaining liberation (*apavarga*). It undertakes a thorough investigation into the nature and validity of knowledge and into the various means which produce valid knowledge, and also into other metaphysical problems. Curiously, Mīmāṃsā has been much influenced by the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika school, many of whose important doctrines it has either borrowed or rejected.

II. Literature of the School

The earliest work of this system is the **Mīmāṃsā-sūtra of Jaimini**, which begins with an inquiry into the nature of Dharma. It is the biggest of all the philosophical sūtra-works and discusses about a thousand topics.

Śabarāsvāmin wrote the great commentary (Bhāṣya) on this work, and his commentary was in turn explained by two later thinkers — **Prabhākara** and **Kumārila Bhaṭṭa** — who differ from each other on certain important points and form the two principal schools of Mīmāṃsā named after them.

- Prabhākara's commentary, the *Bṛhatī*, was commented upon by **Śālikanātha**, who also wrote an independent treatise, the *Prakaraṇa-pañchikā*.
- Kumārila's huge work is divided into three parts — **Śloka-vārtika**, **Tantra-vārtika**, and **Ṭuṭṭikā** — the first of which was commented upon by **Pārthasārathi Miśra**, who also wrote the *Śāstradīpikā*.

Tradition makes Prabhākara a pupil of Kumārila, who nicknamed him 'Guru' on account of his great intellectual powers. But some scholars, such as Dr. Gaṅgānātha Jhā, believe that the Prabhākara school is in fact **older** and seems to be nearer the spirit of the original Mīmāṃsā.

III. Validity of Knowledge

Definitions of Valid Knowledge

- **Prabhākara**: valid knowledge is *apprehension* (anubhūti). All apprehension is direct and immediate and valid *per se*. A cognition which apprehends an object cannot be intrinsically invalid. Memory arises merely from the impression of a prior cognition, and therefore cannot be treated as valid knowledge.
- **Kumārila**: valid knowledge is apprehension of an object which is produced by causes free from defects and which is not contradicted by subsequent knowledge.
- **Pārthasārathi**: valid knowledge is apprehension of an object which has not already been apprehended, which truly represents the object, which is not produced by defective causes, and which is free from contradiction.

The Four Conditions of Valid Cognition

A valid cognition, synthesising these definitions, must fulfil four conditions:

- 1. It must **not arise from defective causes** (kāraṇadoṣarahita).
- 2. It must **be free from contradiction** — self-consistent, and not set aside by subsequent knowledge (bādhakajñānahita).
- 3. It must **apprehend an object not already apprehended** — novelty (agrhitagrāhi) is an essential feature of knowledge; thus memory is excluded from valid knowledge by Kumārila as well.
- 4. It must **truly represent the object** (yathārtha).

The Theory of Svataḥprāmāṇyavāda (Intrinsic / Self-Validity of Knowledge)

The Mīmāṃsaka upholds the theory of **Svataḥprāmāṇyavāda** — the theory of self-validity or intrinsic validity of knowledge. All apprehension is intrinsically valid; all knowledge is valid **by itself**. It is not validated by any other knowledge. Its validity arises from those very causes from which knowledge itself arises. Validity is not due to any extraneous condition.

Both Prabhākara and Kumārila uphold the intrinsic validity of knowledge.

“All cognitions as cognitions are valid; their invalidity is due to their disagreement with the real nature of their objects.”

— Prabhākara

“The validity of knowledge consists in its apprehending an object; it is set aside by such discrepancies as its disagreement with the real nature of the object.”

— Kumārila

All knowledge, therefore, is presumably valid, and our normal life runs smooth on account of this belief. A need for explanation is felt only when knowledge *fails* to be valid; and its invalidity, when it occurs, is inferred either from some defect in the instrument of knowledge or from a subsequent contradicting cognition.

- A person suffering from jaundice sees a white conch as yellow: the knowledge of the yellow conch is invalidated on account of the defect in the organ of vision, i.e., the presence of bile in the eye.
- A rope is mistaken for a snake: the knowledge of the rope-snake is invalidated by the subsequent knowledge of the rope.

Though the *invalidity* of knowledge is inferred, knowledge itself is intrinsically presumed to be valid. Its validity is **not** subject to inference. ‘Truth is normal; error is abnormal. Belief is natural; disbelief is an exception.’

The Mīmāṃsaka advocates the self-validity of knowledge in respect of **both** its origin (utpatti) and its ascertainment (jñapti). The validity of knowledge arises *together with* the knowledge, and is known as soon as the knowledge is known. The very conditions which give rise to knowledge also give rise to its validity as well as to the belief in that validity — neither validity nor belief in validity requires any external condition or any verification by anything else. This is stated in the two aspects of the theory: *prāmāṇyaṃ svataḥ utpadyate* (validity arises by itself) and *prāmāṇyaṃ svataḥ jñāyate cha* (validity is known by itself as soon as the knowledge itself arises).

Mādhavāchārya's Four-fold Classification (Sarvadarśanaśaṅgraha)

Mādhavāchārya has mentioned four theories regarding the validity and invalidity of knowledge:

- 1. **Sāṅkhya**: both the validity (prāmāṇya) and the invalidity (aprāmāṇya) of knowledge are self-evident.
- 2. **Some schools of Buddhism**: knowledge is intrinsically invalid and becomes valid only through extraneous conditions.
- 3. **Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika**: both the validity and the invalidity of knowledge are due to extraneous conditions.

- 4. **Mīmāṃsā**: knowledge is intrinsically valid, though its invalidity is due to extraneous conditions.

The Mīmāṃsaka's Critique of the Sāṅkhya and Buddhist Views

Against Sāṅkhya: the same knowledge cannot be both intrinsically valid and intrinsically invalid — this would be a clear self-contradiction. If it is said that the same knowledge is not regarded as both valid and invalid, but only that valid knowledge reveals its own validity and invalid knowledge reveals its own invalidity, independently of external conditions — then it becomes impossible to *distinguish* valid from invalid knowledge, because invalidity cannot be known without external conditions.

Against the Buddhist view: if knowledge is not intrinsically valid, it can never be validated afterwards — for the second knowledge which is supposed to validate the first is itself knowledge, and being itself intrinsically invalid (on the Buddhist premise) it would require yet another knowledge to validate it, and so on *ad infinitum*.

The Classic Controversy: Mīmāṃsaka versus Naiyāyika

The controversy between the Mīmāṃsaka and the Naiyāyika regarding the validity of knowledge has become classic.

The Nyāya Position — Parataḥprāmāṇyavāda

- Nyāya advocates the theory of **extrinsic validity** of knowledge, called Parataḥprāmāṇyavāda.
- Knowledge is **neither valid nor invalid in itself**; it is neutral. The question of its validity or invalidity arises only after the knowledge has already arisen.
- The nature of knowledge is its **correspondence** with its object, and the test of truth is **fruitful activity** (saṃvādipravṛtti). If knowledge leads to fruitful activity, it is valid; if it does not, it is invalid.
- Validity and invalidity are not intrinsically connected with knowledge — they are the result of a **subsequent test**. Validity is due to excellence (guṇa) in the causes of knowledge; invalidity is due to defect (doṣa) in the causes of knowledge. Knowledge arises simply as knowledge, and only afterwards becomes valid or invalid due to extraneous conditions.

Point of Agreement and Point of Departure

The Mīmāṃsaka **agrees** with the Naiyāyika so far as invalidity (aprāmāṇya) is concerned — both regard invalidity as due to extraneous conditions. But the Mīmāṃsaka **criticises** the Naiyāyika in regard to validity (prāmāṇya): all knowledge, he insists, is intrinsically valid. If the validity of knowledge, like its invalidity, also depended on extraneous conditions, no knowledge would ever become valid at all.

The Naiyāyika's 'Neutral Knowledge' and the Mīmāṃsaka's Rebuttal

The Naiyāyika contends that knowledge arises simply as knowledge, that it is neutral, and that the question of its validity or invalidity arises afterwards and depends on external test.

The Mīmāṃsaka replies that this so-called 'neutral' knowledge is an **impossibility**. We always experience either valid or invalid knowledge; there is no third alternative — we never experience *neutral* knowledge. To maintain otherwise is to hold the absurd position that knowledge, at the moment it arises, is devoid of all logical value. Hence 'neutral knowledge' is no knowledge at all: all

knowledge must be either valid or invalid from the very start.

The Infinite Regress Argument

The Mīmāṃsaka admits that the **invalidity** of knowledge is due to extraneous conditions — e.g. some defect in the causes which produce knowledge, or some contradiction. But the **validity** of knowledge cannot be due to any extraneous condition, since nothing can validate knowledge if knowledge is not already self-valid. The presence of any excellence (guṇa) in the causes of knowledge cannot by itself make it valid, for no such independent excellence is ever actually known or needed — freedom from defect and contradiction is fully sufficient to account for the rise of valid knowledge.

If the validity of knowledge were due to an external condition — such as some excellence in the causes of knowledge, or correspondence, or fruitful activity — then this *second* knowledge (the knowledge of that excellence, correspondence, or fruitful activity) would itself require a *third* knowledge to validate it before it could validate the first knowledge, and so on *ad infinitum*. This fallacy of infinite regress cannot be avoided, since the knowledge of the external validating condition, being itself a piece of knowledge, would in turn require another external condition to validate *it*. Hence all knowledge must be regarded as **self-valid**.

The so-called extraneous conditions — excellence, correspondence, fruitful activity — are, on closer analysis, really neither extraneous nor mere external conditions at all. ‘Excellence’ means only freedom from defect. ‘Fruitful activity’ means only absence of contradiction. ‘Correspondence’ means only true representation of the object. These are the necessary and essential conditions which give rise to valid knowledge in the first place; in their absence, valid knowledge would not arise at all. They are internally and intimately connected with the very causes that produce knowledge, and are hence neither extraneous conditions nor mere tests of the validity of knowledge, but the essential and necessary causes which produce valid knowledge itself. Given these causes, knowledge arises, and it arises **together with** its validity and the belief in that validity.

Comparison with Western Epistemology: Correspondence and Coherence

The Nyāya theory of Parataḥprāmāṇya and the Mīmāṃsā theory of Svataḥprāmāṇya are respectively comparable to the Western theories of **Correspondence** and **Coherence**. Western realism holds that the nature and criterion of truth is correspondence with external reality; Western idealism holds that it is coherence or self-consistency.

The Theory of Correspondence and Its Difficulties

The theory of Correspondence maintains that truth is a determinate and external relation between two distinct and independent things — a one-one relation between ultimately simple elements. Our knowledge, to be true, must correspond to external reality as it is. But this theory is criticised on several grounds:

- A purely external relation is meaningless as well as impossible. If the related terms are conceived as ultimately simple and independent entities, then, being independent, there can be no relation between them at all.
- If the relation falls outside both terms, the relation itself becomes a third entity, which then needs another relation to relate it to the first two terms, and so on *ad infinitum*.

- Relation is possible only within a whole; a mere juxtaposition of so-called atomic or independent entities does not constitute a real whole.
- The external substance is, moreover, unknown and unknowable — it is, as Locke said, an ‘I-know-not-what’. How, then, can we compare our knowledge with an unknowable substance? If we do not know the original, how can we even say that our knowledge is a copy of it? How can knowledge be said to *correspond* to the real?
- Correspondence itself must exist *for* a mind which actively discovers truth and does not merely invent it. Thus the so-called correspondence becomes itself a subsequent experience: when we say our knowledge ‘corresponds’ with reality, what we really mean is that our two experiences are consistent and do not contradict each other. Hence correspondence glides away into **coherence**.

The Theory of Coherence and Its Difficulties

The Coherence theory is advocated by idealists, who believe that Reality is a concrete Identity-in-difference, a real Whole immanent in all its diverse but organically related parts. Reality is the ultimate subject of all our judgments, and a judgment is defined as an ideal content referred to reality. Thought is neither an abstract identity nor a mere difference, but a living process, a significant Whole which is an Identity-in-difference — self-consistent and coherent. Reality is free from contradictions, not because it has annihilated them, but because it has overcome their antagonism within its harmonious bosom. Truth, on this view, is the systematic coherence characteristic of a significant whole.

This theory is criticised on the ground that, according to it, no truth is *completely* true — because coherence, being a matter of discursive judgments, falls short of the concrete coherence which alone is absolute truth. Coherence may serve as a test of truth, but if it is regarded as the very *nature* of truth, then no ‘truth’ can ever be completely true. Coherence is mediacy; and if validity is mediate, no cognition can be absolutely valid.

“In the absence of immediate cognition the principle of coherence would be like a lever without a fulcrum. . . . If mediate cognition could only be mediated by cognitions which are themselves merely mediate, knowledge could never get a start. It is as if one should say that, in building a wall, every brick must be laid on the top of another brick and none directly on the ground.”

— Prof. Stout

Where Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā Stand Relative to These Theories

The Nyāya theory may be compared to the theory of Correspondence: Nyāya advocates realistic pluralism and believes, like the Western realists, that correspondence with external reality is the nature of valid knowledge. But whereas the Western realists make correspondence itself the test of truth, Nyāya realises the difficulty and falls back on an indirect test — that of consistency (saṃvāda) and fruitful activity or practical efficiency (arthakriyājñāna). Here it effectively accepts pragmatism. Mīmāṃsā rightly points out that ‘fruitful activity’ really means nothing more than freedom from contradiction — it is, as Nyāya itself half-heartedly admits, self-consistency (saṃvāda).

The Mīmāṃsā theory of Svataḥprāmāṇya bears a resemblance to the theory of Coherence, but there are striking differences also. The Coherence theory can really be advocated by idealism alone; Mīmāṃsā, by contrast, is a system of rank realism, and believes, like Nyāya, that every piece of knowledge points to an external and independent object beyond itself. It admits, like Nyāya, that

valid knowledge should truly represent the external object — that correspondence with the external object is the nature of valid knowledge (*yathārthaṃ jñānaṃ pramāṇam*). It also agrees with Nyāya that invalidity is due to extraneous conditions. It only insists that, the conditions of freedom from defects and non-contradiction being satisfied, **all** knowledge arises as self-valid.

But this ‘coherence’ of Mīmāṃsā is not the **real** coherence that is characteristic of a significant Whole, because Reality, for Mīmāṃsā, is not a concrete Whole but only a juxtaposition of distinct, independent, atomic entities. The realism of Mīmāṃsā does not allow it to rise to true coherence; and by taking all knowledge as intrinsically valid, it simply dispenses with the need for finding any test for it at all. But by accepting non-contradiction as well as correspondence with the external object as the nature of truth, and further by holding that cognition is immediate apprehension, Mīmāṃsā manages to avoid the criticism levelled against the Coherence theory.

IV. Perception and Inference

Both Prabhākara and Kumārila regard knowledge itself as *pramāṇa* (a means of knowledge). Jaimini admits **three** *pramāṇas* — perception, inference and testimony. Prabhākara adds two more — comparison and implication. Kumārila further adds non-apprehension, making **six** in all.

Perception

Both Prabhākara and Kumārila recognise two kinds of knowledge — immediate and mediate. Perception is regarded as immediate knowledge by both, and both admit two stages within perception: indeterminate and determinate.

- **Prabhākara** defines perception as direct apprehension (*sākṣāt pratītiḥ pratyakṣam*).
- **Kumārila** defines it as direct knowledge produced by the proper contact of the sense-organs with presented objects, free from defects.

Mīmāṃsā broadly agrees with Nyāya's account of perception: the self comes into contact with the mind (*manas*); the mind comes into contact with the sense-organ; the sense-organ comes into contact with the external object.

Differences from the Nyāya Account

- The Mīmāṃsaka regards the auditory organ as proceeding from **space (dik)**, whereas the Naiyāyika regards it as proceeding from **ether (ākāśa)**.
- For Nyāya, indeterminate perception is a stage **inferred afterwards** as a hypothesis to account for determinate perception — all actual perception is determinate, and indeterminate perception serves no fruitful purpose of its own; it is inferred merely as a necessary earlier stage in the complex process of perception.
- For the Mīmāṃsaka, indeterminate perception is part of **normal experience** — it is the vague, indefinite and primitive stage of perception, the awareness of the ‘that’ without its relation to the ‘what’, which gains clarity and definiteness afterwards when it becomes determinate. Like determinate perception, indeterminate perception also serves a fruitful purpose: it is the basis of activity for children and animals and for adults whose mental growth is imperfect. Even normal adults act upon it when they are in a hurry or in confusion. In determinate perception, the self apprehends the pure object (*śuddha vastu*), and though the genuine and specific characters are given in it, their relation to the object is not perceived — it is the bare awareness (*ālōchanamātra*) which is non-relational and therefore indeterminate.

Inference

The Mīmāṃsā account of inference generally agrees with that of Nyāya and need not be repeated in full. There are certain minor differences, however: the Mīmāṃsaka recognises only **three** members of the syllogism — either the first three or the last three — thus bringing the Indian syllogism into conformity with the Aristotelian one.

V. Comparison (Upamāna)

The Mīmāṃsā view of comparison, or *Upamāna*, differs from the Nyāya view.

The Nyāya View

According to Nyāya, comparison is the knowledge of the relation between a word and the object denoted by that word (*saṃjñā-saṃjñisambandhajñāna*). It is the knowledge of the similarity of an unknown object — such as a wild cow — with a known object, such as a cow. The resultant knowledge takes the form: ‘the perceived wild cow is like the remembered cow’ (*gosadr̥śho gavayaḥ*).

The Mīmāṃsā Refutation and Alternative Account

The Mīmāṃsaka refutes this account of comparison. He points out that the knowledge of the relation between a word and the object it denotes is derived from **verbal authority** — e.g., from the words of a person who tells us that a wild cow is similar to a cow — and not from comparison at all. It is known through the recollection of what was learnt from the verbal authority of that person. The knowledge of the wild cow itself, moreover, is due to **perception**, not comparison.

Hence, according to Mīmāṃsā, comparison apprehends the similarity of the **remembered** cow to the **perceived** wild cow — the reverse direction from the Nyāya account. This knowledge takes the form: ‘the remembered cow is like the perceived wild cow’ (*gavayasadr̥śī gauḥ*). It is the cow, as possessing similarity with the wild cow, that is known by comparison. A person need not be told by anybody that a wild cow is similar to a cow; any person who has seen a cow, and who then happens to see a wild cow, himself remembers the cow as similar to the wild cow he is perceiving. This knowledge of similarity **is** comparison. It is distinguished from inference because the invariable concomitance (*vyāpti*) is not needed here.

VI. Verbal Testimony (Śabda)

Śabda-pramāṇa has the greatest importance in Mīmāṃsā. Testimony is verbal authority — the knowledge of supra-sensible objects produced by the comprehension of the meanings of words.

Personal and Impersonal Testimony

Kumārila divides testimony into **personal** (*pauruṣeya*) and **impersonal** (*apauruṣeya*). The former is the testimony of trustworthy persons (*āptavākya*); the latter is the testimony of the Veda (*Vedavākya*).

- The Veda's testimony is **valid in itself** — it has intrinsic validity.
- Personal testimony is **not** valid in itself: its validity is inferred from the trustworthy character of the person, and it may be vitiated by doubt and error and may be contradicted afterwards.

The Veda is eternal and authorless. It is not the work of any person, human or divine — the sages are only the ‘seers’, not the authors, of the Veda; the Veda is not composed or spoken even by God. The Veda deals with Dharma and with objects denoted by it which cannot be known by perception, inference, comparison, or any other means of valid knowledge. Hence the Vedic injunctions can never be contradicted by any subsequent knowledge, and there can be no internal contradictions within the Veda itself. The Vedic testimony is therefore valid in itself.

Prabhākara admits **only** Vedic testimony as real testimony, and reduces human testimony to **inference**, since its validity is inferred from the trustworthy character of the person.

Existential and Injunctive Propositions

Testimony may give us knowledge of existent objects (*siddhārtha vākya*) or may command us to do something (*vidhāyaka vākya*). Kumārila admits the distinction between existential and injunctive propositions and **limits the scope of the Veda to the latter** (*abhihitānvayavāda*). The Veda deals with injunctions; prohibitions are injunctions in disguise. It commands us to do certain things and to refrain from doing certain other things — it deals with the supra-sensible dharma or duty. If we follow the Vedic commands we incur merit; if we do not, we incur demerit. Action, therefore, is the final import of the Veda.

The Veda is broadly divided into **Vidhivāda** (injunctions) and **Arthavāda** (explanations). The existential or assertive propositions of the Veda are merely explanatory passages which explain the injunctions of the Veda — its final import.

Prabhākara takes a strictly **pragmatic** view of all knowledge: knowledge leads to successful activity, and action is the only import of knowledge. He therefore refuses to accept that knowledge deals with existent things at all — all propositions, for him, must be injunctive; all knowledge, whether Vedic or secular, points to activity. The so-called assertive or explanatory propositions in the Veda are authoritative only when they help persons to perform their duties (*anvitābhīdhānavāda*).

Words, Meanings, and Their Relation as Natural and Eternal

Testimony is verbal cognition, derived from the meanings of the words which compose sentences. To uphold the eternality and authorlessness of the Veda, the Mīmāṃsaka puts forward the theory that **words and meanings, as well as their relation, are all natural and eternal**.

- A word (*śabda*) is made up of two or more letters (*varṇa*) and is a mere aggregate of the letters, not a whole (*avayavī*) — though the letters must occur in a particular order.
- A *varṇa* is regarded as an articulated sound. It is **eternal (nitya), omnipresent (sarva-gata), and integral (niravayava)**. It is different from its sound (*dhvani*) if spoken, and different from its symbolic form (*rūpa*) if written. The sound and the form are merely **accidental** features which reveal it; the *varṇa* itself is eternal and immutable, while its *dhvani* and *rūpa* are momentary and changing.
- If many *varṇas* are spoken, they are manifested through a temporal series of utterances; if written, through a spatial series of written symbols. The sound and the symbol are only the **vehicles** of the manifestation of the eternal *varṇa*. When a *varṇa* is pronounced or written in ten different ways, there are not ten different *varṇas* but only ten different **manifestations** of the same *varṇa*.
- A word — being an aggregate of two or more eternal *varṇas* — is itself eternal. A word does not signify the particular things which come into existence and pass away, but the **eternal**

universals underlying these particulars. The meanings or objects denoted by words, being universals, are therefore eternal and unchanging.

- The relation between a word and its meaning, being natural, necessary, inseparable and internal, is **eternal and unchanging**. This relation is **not conventional**: it is due neither to God's will (as the old school of Nyāya believes) nor to convention (as the modern school of Nyāya believes). It is natural and eternal. Language is not a creation of the human, or even the divine, mind — philology is a natural science. The conventional element in language is only **secondary** (sahakāri) and helps the manifestation of the eternal words and their meanings, just as light helps the manifestation of sight.

The Naiyāyika also believes in the authority of the Veda, but regards the Veda as the work of God, and so challenges its eternality and authorlessness — for him, words are not eternal, and language is due either to divine will or to convention. The Mīmāṃsaka refutes this view and points out that only the **sounds and the symbols** are created and destroyed, while the **real words are eternal**; words are manifested through human efforts, and the sounds and symbols are merely the vehicles of the manifestation of the eternal words.

The Eternality of the Veda as a Text

But even the permanence of the word, its meaning, and their relation, does not by itself make the Veda eternal — for the Veda is a literary work consisting of sounds and symbols. On the Mīmāṃsā view, all the uttered or written words are really permanent, though the sounds and the symbols through which they are manifested may be evanescent and changing. What, then, is the difference between the Veda and any other literary work? The Mīmāṃsaka answers that the Veda is **authorless**, while all other works are the creation of their authors. The order in which words occur in ordinary literary works is determined by their authors, and is therefore subject to defects, doubts and errors. But the order in which the words occur in the Veda is **self-determined** and therefore intrinsically valid.

The Veda is not the creation of any author, human or divine; it is self-proved and self-manifesting. The particular order (*ānupūrvī*) in which the words occur in the Veda is self-determined and eternal. It is this permanence of the very **text** of the Veda that is emphasised by the Mīmāṃsaka. The Veda, together with its text, is eternal and authorless because its words, their meanings, and their relation are all eternal, and because long-standing tradition is silent on the question of the authorship of the Veda.

Sharma's critical remark: this view of the Mīmāṃsā cannot be supported by any rational argument, and remains, more or less, a theological dogma.

VII. Implication (Arthāpatti)

Prabhākara and Kumārila both, unlike the Naiyāyika, admit **Arthāpatti** as an independent means of valid knowledge. It is presumption, postulation, or implication: the assumption of an unperceived fact in order to reconcile two apparently inconsistent perceived facts.

The Classic Illustrations

- If Devadatta is alive and he is not in his house, we presume that he is elsewhere. 'Being alive' and 'not being in the house' are two perceived facts which appear inconsistent; the apparent inconsistency is removed when we presume the fact of his 'being elsewhere'.

- If Devadatta is fat and does not eat during the day, we presume that he must be eating during the night — otherwise the inconsistency between ‘being fat’ and ‘not eating during the day’ cannot be explained.

The Naiyāyika reduces presumption to inference. The Mīmāṃsaka regards it as an **independent pramāṇa**.

Prabhākara and Kumārila on What Distinguishes Presumption from Inference

- **Prabhākara**: the element of **doubt** distinguishes presumption from inference. In presumption there must be a doubt regarding the truth of the two perceived facts, and this doubt is removed by the presumption; in inference there is no such doubt.
- **Kumārila**: doubt is **not** the basis of presumption. The basis is the **mutual inconsistency** of the two perceived facts, which inconsistency is removed by the presumption. In inference there is no such inconsistency.

Prabhākara and Kumārila both agree, however, that in presumption there is **no middle term** at all — which is the very basis of inference. Neither of the two perceived, apparently inconsistent facts can separately serve as a middle term; and the two facts *combined* would already include the conclusion, whereas a valid middle term must never include the conclusion. Hence presumption is different in kind from inference.

The Naiyāyika's Counter: Reduction to Categorical Syllogism

The Naiyāyika points out that presumption is really **disjunctive reasoning**, which can be reduced to categorical form. If alive Devadatta is not at his house, the fact of his being elsewhere is inferred thus:

Alive Devadatta is either in his house or elsewhere.

Alive Devadatta is not in his house.

Therefore, alive Devadatta is elsewhere.

This disjunctive reasoning can in turn be reduced to a categorical syllogistic form:

All alive persons who are not in their house are elsewhere.

Devadatta is an alive person who is not in his house.

Therefore, Devadatta is an alive person who is elsewhere.

Similarly, for the fat Devadatta who does not eat during the day:

Fat Devadatta eats either during day or night.

Fat Devadatta does not eat during day.

Therefore, fat Devadatta eats during night.

Reduced to categorical form:

All fat persons who do not eat during day are persons who eat during night.

Devadatta is a fat person who does not eat during day.

Therefore, Devadatta is a fat person who eats during night.

VIII. Negation (Anupalabdhi)

Kumārila admits **non-apprehension** (anupalabdhi) as the sixth independent pramāṇa. Both the Naiyāyika and Prabhākara reject it — but for different reasons.

The Naiyāyika's Position

The Naiyāyika, like Kumārila, admits negation as an **independent ontological category**; but, unlike Kumārila, he does not believe in non-apprehension as an independent **means of knowledge** for knowing negation. According to him, negation is known either by perception or by inference, according as the correlate (*pratiyogī*) of the negation is itself an object of perception or of inference: the same sense-organ which perceives an object also perceives its non-existence, and the same inference which infers the existence of an object also infers its non-existence. Thus, though negation is a separate category for the Naiyāyika, non-apprehension as a separate pramāṇa is not required as its means — he reduces non-apprehension to perception or inference.

Prabhākara's Position

Prabhākara does not admit negation itself as an independent category at all, and hence has no need to admit non-apprehension as its means. He agrees with the Naiyāyika, against Kumārila, in rejecting non-apprehension as a separate pramāṇa; but he differs from the Naiyāyika in also rejecting negation as a separate category. For him, negation can be represented as a **positive entity**: there is no non-existence over and above existence. Existence may be perceived either in itself, or as related to something else; the apprehension of bare existence — of the locus in itself — is **wrongly called** non-existence. Thus the so-called 'non-existence of the jar on the ground' is nothing but the apprehension of the bare ground itself; the so-called 'non-existence of a jar before its production' is nothing but the clay itself.

Kumārila's Refutation of Both Prabhākara and Nyāya

Kumārila, siding with the Naiyāyika on the reality of the category, refutes Prabhākara's view, maintaining that non-existence or negation exists as a **separate category**, different from bare existence or the locus itself. Negation is not mere nothing. When we perceive the bare ground, we perceive **neither** the jar **nor** its non-existence — hence the perception of the bare ground is different from both the non-existence and the non-cognition of the jar.

Kumārila also refutes the Naiyāyika's view that non-apprehension may be reduced to perception or inference:

- Negation cannot be perceived, for there is no sense-object contact with it.
- Negation cannot be inferred, for the invariable concomitance (*vyāpti*) is not known here.
- Negation cannot be known by testimony, for there is no verbal cognition here.
- Nor can it be known from comparison or from presumption.

Hence negation, being an independent category, is known by an equally independent pramāṇa called **non-apprehension**.

IX. Nature of Knowledge

Prabhākara: Knowledge as Self-Luminous (Triputīpratyakṣavāda)

Prabhākara's theory of knowledge is known as **tripuṭīpratyakṣavāda**. He regards knowledge as **self-luminous** (svaprakāśa): it manifests itself and needs nothing else for its manifestation. Though self-luminous, knowledge is **not eternal** — it arises and vanishes.

Knowledge reveals itself, and as it does so, it **simultaneously** reveals its subject and its object. In every knowledge-situation we have this **triple revelation**. The subject and the object are both manifested by knowledge itself, simultaneously with its own manifestation. Cognition is known as cognition; the self is known as the knower, and it can **never** be cognised as an object; an object is known as a known object. The *tripuṭī* of the knower (*jñātā*), the known (*jñeya*), and the knowledge (*jñāna*) is simultaneously revealed in every single act of cognition.

The self and the object both **depend** on knowledge for their manifestation. The self, therefore, is **not** itself self-luminous — it is not cognised in deep sleep, because there is then no knowledge present to manifest it. Every act of knowledge has, accordingly, a **triple manifestation**: the cognition of the self as the knower (*ahaṃvitti*), the cognition of the object as the known (*viśayavitti*), and the self-conscious cognition (*svaṃvitti*).

Kumārila: Knowledge as Inferred (Jñātatāvāda)

Kumārila's theory of knowledge is known as **jñātatāvāda**. He differs from Prabhākara and does **not** regard knowledge as self-luminous. Knowledge, for him, is **not perceptible** — it cannot be known directly and immediately. Kumārila regards knowledge as a **mode of the self**, essentially an act (*kriyā*) or a process (*vyāpāra*). It cannot reveal itself, nor can it be revealed by another cognition, as the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika believes. It can only be **inferred** — inferred from the **cognizedness** (*jñātatā*) or manifestness/illuminedness (*prākāṣya*) of its object.

Knowledge is the means of knowing the object, and it is inferred as such **because without it the object could never have become known** by the subject. Cognition relates the self to the object and enables it to know the object; it is the act of the self by which it knows an object, and it is inferred from the fact that the object **has become 'known'** by the self — the cognitive act is inferred from the cognizedness of the object.

The Analogy of Cooking Rice

Kumārila illustrates this with the analogy of an act, which involves four things: an agent (*kartā*), an object (*karma*), an instrument (*karaṇa*), and a result (*phala*). Consider rice being cooked: the cook is the agent; the rice-grain is the object; the fire is the instrument; the cookedness or softness of the rice is the result. The **act** of cooking is found in the agent, but its **result** is found in the object.

Similarly, cognition arises **in the self**, but its result — 'cognizedness' — is seen in the object known. Just as a person who has not himself seen the rice being cooked can nevertheless infer, from the 'cookedness' or 'softness' of the rice, that the act of cooking must have taken place before that softness arose in it, so too the act of cognition is inferred to have taken place in the self by the fact that the object has become **cognized**.

Knowledge is thus the *tertium quid* between the knower and the known. It is a **modal change** (*pariṇāma*) in the self, and as such it is **adventitious** (*āgantuka*) rather than essential. It produces a peculiarity — a result (*atiśaya*) — in its object, and it is inferred from the cognizedness of that object. Cognition manifests the object and is itself inferred by this fact; it cannot manifest itself, nor

can it be manifested by any other cognition.

X. Prabhākara's Theory of Error — Akhyāti

We have seen that, on the theory of intrinsic validity of knowledge, all knowledge is held to be self-valid by the Mīmāṃsaka; validity is inherent in knowledge, while invalidity is inferred on account of some defect or contradiction in the causes of knowledge. But if all knowledge is self-valid, how can error arise at all? Prabhākara and Kumārila give different answers to this question: Prabhākara's view is known as **Akhyāti**, and Kumārila's as **Viparītakhyāti**.

Error as Non-Apprehension, Not Mis-Apprehension

Prabhākara, in strict accordance with his view of the intrinsic validity of knowledge, **does not admit error in the logical sense at all**. All knowledge is valid *per se*; to experience is always to experience validly. Error, therefore, is only **partial truth** — it is imperfect knowledge. All knowledge, as knowledge, is quite valid, though all knowledge is not necessarily *perfect*. Imperfect knowledge is commonly called 'error', but error is true so far as it goes; only it does not go far enough. All knowledge being true in this sense, there can be no **logical** distinction between truth and error.

Prabhākara is true to his realistic position in maintaining that knowledge can never **misrepresent** its object. Error is one of **omission only, never of commission**. It is only **non-apprehension**, not mis-apprehension. It is not a unitary knowledge, not a single psychosis, but is, in fact, a **composite of two cognitions** which really fall apart, unrelated. Error is due to **non-discrimination** between these two cognitions and their separate objects — it is a mere non-apprehension of the distinction between the two cognitions and their objects. Hence this view is called **akhyāti**, or non-apprehension.

The Two Factors of Error

Error arises when we forget the fact that, instead of one cognition, there are really **two** cognitions denoting two separate objects, and further forget that these two cognitions, as well as their objects, are distinct and unrelated. Two factors are involved in error:

- A **positive** factor: the presence of two cognitions which reveal their respective objects only **partially**.
- A **negative** factor: the overlooking of the distinction between these two cognitions and their objects.

Both cognitions may be presentative, or both may be representative, or one may be presentative and the other representative:

- If **both** cognitions are presentative, error is due to non-discrimination between perception and perception.
- If **both** are representative, error is due to non-discrimination between memory and memory.
- If **one is presentative** and the **other representative**, error is due to non-discrimination between perception and memory.

In all cases, error is due to non-discrimination, which means non-apprehension of the distinction between the two cognitions and their objects. Hence this view is also called **vivekākhyāti**, or **bhedāgraha**, or **asaṃsargāgraha**.

Illustrations

(1) The Jaundiced Eye

When a person suffering from jaundice sees a white conch as yellow, two cognitions arise. There is a cognition of the conch as the 'this' minus its white colour, and there is also a cognition of the yellow colour alone, of the bile. Both these cognitions are partial and imperfect, though quite valid as far as they go. The conch is perceived as the 'this', and not as the 'conch'; the bile is perceived as the 'yellowness', and not as the 'bile'. The distinction between the 'this' of the conch and the 'yellowness' of the bile is not apprehended. Here there is non-discrimination between perception and perception, as both cognitions are presentative in character.

(2) The Crystal and the Red Flower

Similarly, when a white crystal is perceived as red on account of a red flower placed near it, there is non-apprehension of the distinction between two cognitions which are partial and imperfect — the cognition of the crystal minus its whiteness, and the cognition of the redness alone, of the flower. Here again there is non-discrimination between two partial perceptions.

(3) The Remembered Snake

Again, if a person recollects that he saw a long snake lying on the road yesterday, when really he saw only a piece of rope, here also two imperfect cognitions arise — the recollection of the rope as the 'that' minus its ropeness, and the recollection of the snake 'robbed of its thatness'. Here there is non-discrimination between two **memory-images**.

(4) The Shell Mistaken for Silver

Again, when a person mistakes a piece of shell for a piece of silver and says, 'this is silver', two imperfect cognitions arise. The 'this' of the shell is actually perceived, together with certain qualities like whiteness and brightness which the shell shares in common with silver, but minus its shellness. These common qualities revive in memory the impression of silver which the person has perceived previously elsewhere. Silver is imported in memory merely as silver, 'robbed of its thatness' (*pramuṣṭatattākasmaraṇa*). Silver is thus represented as a memory-image, though at the time the fact of its being only a memory-image, and not perception, is forgotten due to a certain defect (*smṛtipramoṣa*). And the discrimination between the perceived 'this' of the shell and the remembered 'silver' (without its thatness) is **not apprehended**.

Here there is non-discrimination between perception and memory, between a **presented** thing and a **represented** image. There is only non-apprehension of the distinction between these two imperfect cognitions and their partially presented objects. But there is **no misapprehension**, because the 'shell' is not mis-perceived as 'silver', since the shell never actually enters consciousness at all. The 'this' is never sublated: when the error is exposed, the person says, '*this* is shell'.

XI. Kumārila's Theory of Error — Viparītakhyāti

Kumārila agrees with Prabhākara in maintaining the intrinsic validity of knowledge. But he differs from Prabhākara inasmuch as he maintains the **logical distinction** between truth and error. He recognises error **as such** and regards it as **misapprehension**, and not as mere non-apprehension. He further holds that error is a **single psychosis**, a *unitary* knowledge, and not a composite of two imperfect cognitions. Error, for Kumārila, is not only of omission, but also of **commission**.

Agreement and Disagreement with Prabhākara

Kumārila agrees with Prabhākara in maintaining that in the erroneous perception ‘this is silver’, two things are indeed present: the shell is perceived as the ‘this’ bereft of its shellness, and silver is imported in memory merely as silver bereft of its thatness, on account of the qualities of whiteness and brightness common to both shell and silver. But he **differs** from Prabhākara in maintaining that there is a **positive wrong synthesis** of these two elements — the perceived and the remembered — and that error is not due merely to the non-apprehension of the distinction between them. The two elements are **not united in fact**, but they **appear to be so in error**.

Error as Positive Misapprehension

Error, for Kumārila, is partial **misrepresentation**. It is not *akhyāti* or non-apprehension, but *viparīta-khyāti*, or misapprehension. It is not due to non-discrimination between two imperfect cognitions (*vivekākhyāti*, *bhedāgraha*, or *asaṃsargāgraha*), but due to a **positive wrong synthesis** of the two imperfect cognitions which, though in fact unrelated, are welded together as a **unitary knowledge in error** (*saṃsargagraha* or *viparītagraha*). Thus error becomes a single psychosis, a unitary cognition, a positive misapprehension — and therefore one of **commission**. The shell is **misperceived** as silver.

Error, on this view, is a wrong apprehension of one object **as** another object which, in fact, it is not. This misapprehension arises due to some defect in the causes of knowledge, and is set aside by a subsequent sublating knowledge. But as long as error is experienced, it is valid as a cognition *per se* — its intrinsic validity is set aside only by extraneous conditions, such as defects in the causes of cognition, or by a contradicting cognition.

Kumārila thus **gives up his realism** to the extent that he admits a subjective or ideal element in error. When error is regarded as misapprehension, the subjective element inevitably creeps into it. Though the two *relata* (shell and silver) are separately real, the **relation** between them is not so.

XII. Nyāya Theory of Error — Anyathākhyāti

Kumārila's Viparīta-khyāti is much similar to the **Anyathā-khyāti** of the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, though there are certain differences in detail. The Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika also believes, like Kumārila, that error is due to a wrong synthesis of the presented and the represented objects.

The Nyāya Account

The represented object is confused with the presented one. The word ‘*anyathā*’ means both ‘elsewise’ and ‘elsewhere’, and both meanings are brought out in error: the presented object is perceived **elsewise**, and the represented object exists **elsewhere**. The shell and the silver are both separately real; only their synthesis — their relation as ‘shell-silver’ — is unreal. The shell is misperceived as silver, which in fact exists elsewhere, e.g., in the market (*āpaṇastha*).

The Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, like Kumārila, recognises the **subjective element** in error: error is due to a wrong synthesis of the presented objects.

“What is set aside by true knowledge is the wrong apprehension, not the object.”

— Vātsyāyana

“The object all the while remains what it actually is . . . the error lies in the cognition.”

— Uddyotakara

"A real object is mistaken as another real object which exists elsewhere."

— Gaṅgeśa

The Difference Between Kumārila and the Naiyāyika

The essential difference between the Naiyāyika and Kumārila is that while Kumārila is **boldly prepared to forsake his realism** to the extent of maintaining the ideal element in error, the Naiyāyika, in order to preserve his realism, falls back — somewhat vainly — upon **extraordinary perception** to explain the revival of 'silver' in memory. He maintains that this revival of 'silver' in memory is due to a 'complicated perception' (*jñānalakṣaṇapratyakṣa*), a variety of extraordinary (*alaukika*) perception. Thus he wants to make the represented silver into something **actually perceived**, though in an extraordinary way. Kumārila admits **no such extraordinary perception**.

Divergence on the Nature of Truth

The Naiyāyika further differs from Kumārila in maintaining that knowledge is **not intrinsically valid** but becomes so only on account of extraneous conditions. He regards correspondence as the nature of truth; but realising the difficulty that correspondence cannot itself serve as the *test* of truth, he proposes **successful activity** (*saṃvādapravṛtti*) as the test of truth, and accepts pragmatism so far as the criterion of truth is concerned.

Kumārila, by contrast, holds **non-contradiction** to be the very nature of truth, and regards all knowledge as intrinsically valid; knowledge becomes invalid only when some defect is discovered in the causes of knowledge, or when it is set aside by a subsequent sublating cognition. Kumārila thus takes a detached and scientific view of both truth and error.

Prabhākara, rejecting alike the Naiyāyika's theory of the extrinsic validity of truth and the Naiyāyika's and Kumārila's account of error as positive misapprehension — and maintaining no logical distinction between truth and error at all — falls back on the Naiyāyika's **pragmatic test** of truth, agreeing with him that truth is that which 'works', and error is that which does not, and lacks practical worth.

XIII. Rāmānuja's Theory of Error — Satkhyāti

The view of error found in earlier Sāṅkhya, and in Rāmānuja — technically called **sat-khyāti** — is similar to the view of Prabhākara's *akhyāti*. Earlier Sāṅkhya, Prabhākara, and Rāmānuja all believe that error is **non-apprehension**, not misapprehension. Error is only **partial truth**; cognition as such is never invalid; error means imperfect and incomplete truth. The way to remove error is simply to acquire more perfect and complete knowledge. There is **no subjective or ideal element** in error on this view; truth only **supplements** error, and does not cancel it.

Rāmānuja's Modification

Rāmānuja adopts Prabhākara's theory with a certain modification, and his own theory is variously called **yathārthakhyāti**, or **satkhyāti**, or **akhyāti-saṃvalitasatkhyāti**, or 'Non-apprehension-cum-apprehension of Reality'. Rāmānuja goes so far as to say that the shell appears as silver **because there are actually some particles of silver in it**, and he explains this through his own interpretation of triplication or quintuplication (*trivṛt-karaṇa* or *pañchī-karaṇa*).

All apprehension, on this view, is **real** (*yathārthaṃ sarvavijñānam*). Error is right so far as it goes; only it does not go sufficiently far enough. The distinction between error and truth, therefore, is not logical, but only **practical**.

Rāmānuja versus Prabhākara

The difference between Prabhākara and Rāmānuja is that Prabhākara is content with the mere **non-apprehension of the distinction** between the perceived shell and the remembered silver, whereas Rāmānuja advocates the **real perception** of an actual element of silver in the shell itself. And while Prabhākara takes a fully pragmatic view of knowledge — regarding knowledge as only a means to successful activity — Rāmānuja 'values knowledge more for the light it brings than for the fruits it bears'.

Sadasatkhyāti of Later Sāṅkhya and Jainism

The later Sāṅkhya (as in the Sāṅkhya-sūtra) and Jainism believe in **Sadasatkhyāti**, which agrees mainly with the view of Kumārila. Error, on this view, is regarded as misapprehension, due to a **wrong synthesis** of two cognitions which are separately real, though the synthesis itself is unreal (*asat*).

XIV. Theory of Error in Mahāyāna and Advaita Vedānta — Anirvachanīyakhyāti

We have thus far considered the theories of error found in those schools which claim to be **realistic** in one way or another. These realistic schools are divided, in their view of error, into **two broad groups**:

- Those which regard error as mere **non-apprehension** and reject the subjective element in error altogether — the *akhyāti* of Prabhākara, the *satkhyāti* of earlier Sāṅkhya, and the *akhyāti-saṃvalitasatkhyāti* (*yathārtha-khyāti*) of Rāmānuja. Error is here treated as **partial truth**.
- Those which regard error as **misapprehension** and admit the subjective element in error — the *vīparītakhyāti* of Kumārila, the *anyathākhyāti* of Nyāya, and the *sadasatkhyāti* of later Sāṅkhya and Jainism. Error is here treated as **partial misrepresentation**.

Sharma's Critical Assessment: Why All Realistic Theories Fail

All these theories, however, fail to account satisfactorily for the fact of error.

Against ‘Error as Mere Non-Apprehension’

Error cannot be taken as mere non-apprehension, for there is definitely a **subjective element** involved in error, which is later contradicted by the sublating cognition. This view ignores the fact that, as long as error lasts, it is taken as **true** and prompts activity, even though that activity may result in failure. There is an **actual presentation** of ‘silver’ to consciousness, and not a mere memory-image. If the two cognitions stand apart, unrelated, and error is due to mere non-apprehension of their distinction, the natural question arises: do these two cognitions appear in consciousness or not? If they do, then there must be a cognition of their distinction also; if they do not, then they are unreal. Again, neither correspondence nor pragmatic activity can be taken as the nature or the test of truth. And Prabhākara, at least, has no right to maintain ‘non-apprehension’ at all, since he rejects negation itself as an independent category.

Against ‘Error as Misapprehension’

The other group, which regards error as misapprehension, equally fails to explain error. If error is purely subjective — if knowledge can misrepresent its object — then realism itself stands rejected. How, after all, can the shell be misperceived as silver? Silver cannot be perceived, because it is not there, and there can be no sense-contact with it. Nor can it be a mere memory-image, because as long as error lasts, there is an **actual presentation** of silver to consciousness. The extraordinary *jñānalakṣaṇa* perception admitted by Nyāya is a mere **arbitrary assumption**.

The dilemma before the realist is this: if silver is real, it cannot be contradicted afterwards by the sublating cognition of shell; and if silver is unreal, how can it appear to consciousness during the error at all? Realism cannot give any satisfactory answer to this dilemma.

The Idealist Solution: Anirvachanīyakhyāti

This question is answered by the idealist schools of **Mahāyāna Buddhism** and **Advaita Vedānta**. Śūnyavāda, Vijñānavāda, and Advaita Vedānta all advocate the view known as **anirvachanīyakhyāti**.

Orthodox tradition — probably because the original works of Śūnyavāda and Vijñānavāda were not available to it — ascribes to Śūnyavāda the view of **asatkhyāti** (that the object of cognition is unreal, since reality itself is void), and to Vijñānavāda the view of **ātmakhyāti** (that error is the superimposition of the form of cognition upon the so-called external object, which is unreal, since the only reality is the momentary cognition). But it is a **great blunder**, Sharma insists, to ascribe these views to these schools: neither is Śūnyavāda nihilism, nor is Vijñānavāda subjective idealism. Both, properly understood, believe in **Absolute Idealism** and are the forerunners of Advaita Vedānta. (Only the school of **Svatantra-vijñānavāda** may rightly be charged with subjective idealism and regarded as an advocate of *ātmakhyāti* — a theory which is clearly absurd, for according to it, instead of ‘this is silver’ we should have the cognition ‘I am silver’, or at least ‘the idea of “this” is the idea of silver’.)

The True Solution of the Three Schools of Absolute Idealism

Reality is pure consciousness, direct, immediate, and self-luminous — the transcendental background of the world of phenomena, which is its appearance due to the power of beginningless Ignorance (*Avidyā*). Affirmation and negation are phases of the same reality. The distinction between truth and error is **relative and empirical**; Reality transcends this distinction altogether.

Error, on this view, is of **two kinds**:

- The **transcendental or universal** error — called by Śūnyavāda *tathya-samvṛti*, by Vijñānavāda *paratantra*, and by Vedānta *vyavahāra*.
- The **subjective or individual** error — called by Śūnyavāda *mithyā-samvṛti*, by Vijñānavāda *parikalpita*, and by Vedānta *pratibhāsa*.

For convenience, the former is called ‘**appearance**’ and the latter ‘**error**’. Both are based on contradiction, negativity, limitation, and relativity; both baffle all description and are the offspring of the real and the unreal alike; both are strictly **indescribable** — they can be called **neither real nor unreal**. Contradiction is the very essence of all appearances, for non-contradiction belongs only to Reality, which is of the nature of pure knowledge. Knowledge, therefore, removes contradiction, and the moment contradiction is removed, error vanishes.

When the shell is mistaken for silver, the shell-delimited consciousness is the ground on which ‘silver’ and its cognition are illusorily imposed by beginningless Ignorance. This ‘silver’ is **not real**, because it is contradicted afterwards when the shell is known; and it **cannot be unreal** either, because it appears as silver as long as the illusion lasts. It is, therefore, called *anirvachanīya* — indescribable — as either real or unreal.

Avidyā hides the true nature of the shell and makes it look like silver: negatively, it **covers** shellness (*āvaraṇa*); positively, it **projects** (*vikṣepa*) silver upon it. Error is an indescribable superimposition which does **not really affect** the ground, and which is removed by right knowledge. Error is true as long as it lasts, and becomes unreal only when it is contradicted by a higher knowledge. The illusory is sublated by the phenomenal, and the phenomenal, in turn, is sublated by the transcendental.

XV. Realism of Mīmāṃsā (Metaphysics)

We now turn to the metaphysics of Mīmāṃsā. The Mīmāṃsaka is a **pluralistic realist**. He believes in the reality of the external world and of the individual souls. There are innumerable individual souls — as many as there are living bodies — plus the bodiless liberated souls. There are also innumerable atoms and other eternal and infinite substances.

Mīmāṃsā believes in the **Law of Karma**, in the **Unseen Power** (*apūrva*), in heaven and hell, in liberation, and in the ultimate authority of the eternal, authorless Veda. **God is ruled out** as an unnecessary hypothesis, though the later Mīmāṃsakas, like Āpadeva and Laugākṣi, try to bring God back in.

Mīmāṃsā does not admit the periodic creation and dissolution of the world. The world was never created, and never shall it be destroyed. Though individuals come and go, and though finite material products arise and perish, the world as such — the universe as a whole — goes on for ever, uncreated and imperishable: ‘There never was a time when the universe was different from what it is now’ (*na kadāchid anīdṛśaṃ jagat*).

The Categories

Prabhākara admits **seven** categories: substance (*dravya*), quality (*guṇa*), action (*karma*), generality (*sāmānya*), inherence (*paratantratā*), force (*śakti*), and similarity (*sādrśya*). Of these, the first five are similar to the categories of the Vaiśeṣika, though inherence is here called *paratantratā* instead of *samavāya*; the last two, *śakti* and *sādrśya*, are additions of his own. The Vaiśeṣika category of particularity is equated with the quality of distinctness (*pṛthaktva*), and the Vaiśeṣika category of negation is **rejected**.

Kumārila recognises **four** positive categories — substance, quality, action, and generality — together with a fifth category of **negation**, which is itself of four kinds: prior, posterior, mutual, and absolute. He rejects particularity and inherence altogether. Like Prabhākara, he reduces particularity to the quality of distinctness. Inherence he reduces to **identity-in-difference** (*tādātmya* or *bhedābheda*) — an identity between two different but inseparable objects. Kumārila, like Śaṅkara, criticises the reality of inherence, and says that, in order to avoid an infinite regress, inherence must be regarded as identity, which is really identity-in-difference.

Kumārila rejects force and similarity as independent categories and includes them under substance. He admits the nine substances of the Vaiśeṣika and adds two more — **darkness** and **sound** — which are rejected by Prabhākara. In general, the conception of the categories and the substances etc. in Mīmāṃsā is much the same as in the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika.

XVI. Self and Knowledge

Prabhākara and Kumārila both admit the **plurality** of individual souls, and regard the self as an eternal (*nitya*), omnipresent (*sarvagata*), ubiquitous (*vibhu*), infinite (*vyāpaka*) substance (*dravya*) — the substratum (*āśraya*) of consciousness, and a real knower (*jñātā*), enjoyer (*bhoktā*), and agent (*kartā*). The self is different from the body, the senses, the mind and the understanding. The self is the enjoyer (*bhoktā*); the body is the vehicle of enjoyment (*bhogāyatana*); the senses are the instruments of enjoyment (*bhogasādhana*); and internal feelings and external things are the objects of enjoyment (*bhogyaviṣaya*).

Is Consciousness the Essence of the Self?

Consciousness is **not** regarded as the essence of the self. **Prabhākara**, agreeing with the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, holds that the self is essentially **unconscious** (*jaḍa*), and that consciousness is only an **accidental quality** which the soul-substance may or may not possess. Cognitions, feelings, and volitions are properties of the self and arise due to merit and demerit. In liberation — which comes about through the exhaustion of merit and demerit — the self remains as a pure substance divested of all its qualities, including consciousness and bliss.

Kumārila, differing from Prabhākara and the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, regards consciousness as a **modal change** (*pariṇāma*) in the self. It is a mode, an act, a process of the self by which the self cognizes objects — neither the essence of the self nor a mere accidental static property of it. Kumārila, like the Jainas, regards the self as **identical as well as different**, as **changeless as well as changing**. As substance, it does not change and always remains the same; as modes, it undergoes change and becomes diverse. The substance remains the same; it is only the modes which appear and disappear. Modal change does not militate against the permanence of the self.

The self, for Kumārila, is not wholly unconscious as Prabhākara and the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika believe. It is **conscious-unconscious** (*jaḍabodhātmaka* or *chidachidrūpa*): as substance it is unconscious, as modes it is conscious. The self is characterised by the **potency to know** — potential consciousness is the very nature of the self (*jñānaśaktisvabhāva*). Kumārila too, like Prabhākara and the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, believes that in liberation the self remains a pure substance divested of all qualities and modes, including consciousness and bliss — though he adds that the self, even then, as in deep sleep, is characterised by **potential** consciousness.

How Is the Self Known?

Prabhākara, Kumārila and the Naiyāyika give different answers to the question: how is the self known?

Prabhākara: Simultaneous Revelation

Prabhākara advocates the theory of the **simultaneous revelation** of knower, known, and knowledge (*tripuṭīpratyakṣavāda*). He believes, like the Naiyāyika, that the self is essentially unconscious; but unlike him, he maintains that **knowledge is self-luminous**. Self-luminous knowledge reveals the self as the subject and the known thing as the object, simultaneously with itself. In every knowledge-situation, the self is simultaneously revealed as the subject of that knowledge. The self is **not** itself self-luminous, because it is not revealed in deep sleep — it is unconscious like the object, and, like the object, requires knowledge for its manifestation. Knowledge is not eternal, though the self is; knowledge appears and disappears, and as it does so it reveals the self as the subject and the known thing as the object, together with itself. The self is necessarily implied in every act of knowledge **as the subject**, and it can never itself become an object — it is impossible to know the self as an object. All consciousness is necessarily self-consciousness.

Kumārila: Inference through Cognizedness

Kumārila advocates the theory of the **cognizedness of the object** (*jñātatāvāda*). He believes, like the Naiyāyika and unlike Prabhākara, that self-consciousness is a **later and higher** state of consciousness. But whereas the Naiyāyika believes that both consciousness and the self are **directly revealed** in this higher state of self-consciousness through introspection (*anuvyavasāya*), Kumārila believes that consciousness is only **inferred indirectly** through the cognizedness (*jñātatā* or *prākṛtya*) of the object, though the self **is** directly revealed as the object of self-consciousness, or the I-notion, or the Ego-cognition.

According to Kumārila, the self is **not** revealed as the subject by consciousness together with itself: consciousness can reveal neither itself nor the subject — it can reveal only the object. Consciousness is **not** self-luminous; it is not known directly; it is inferred through the cognizedness of the object. Consciousness is a dynamic mode of the self, and its result is seen only in the object which becomes illumined by it. Hence the self is known as the **object** of the I-notion.

Kumārila takes 'self-consciousness' in its **literal** sense. The self is of the nature of the 'I', and it is apprehended by itself and by nothing else. It is an object of the I-consciousness. The self is both the subject and the object; there is no contradiction in maintaining this, because the self becomes an object only **to itself** and to nothing else. The knower becomes the known — **to itself**.

Sharma's Critical Evaluation

It is clear from this account that Prabhākara and Kumārila both struggle for the correct view of the self, though both, in the end, miss it.

- **Prabhākara** is right in maintaining that knowledge is self-luminous, and that the self as subject is necessarily involved in every knowledge-situation, and that the self which is the subject can never be known as an object. But he is wrong in confusing pure knowledge with momentary cognitions, and in regarding the self as an unconscious substance with consciousness as its merely accidental quality.
- **Kumārila** is right in saying that consciousness is not an accidental quality of the self, that the self is not explicitly revealed in all knowledge, and that self-consciousness is higher than mere consciousness. But he is wrong in saying that consciousness is a dynamic mode of the self, in confusing the self with the ego, in denying the self-luminosity of knowledge and reducing it to a thing only to be inferred, and in treating the self as the mere object of the I-notion.

The real self, Sharma concludes, is the **transcendental knower**, and, as ultimate subject, is identical with eternal and foundational consciousness. Prabhākara and Kumārila, influenced by the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika in their pluralistic realism, fail to treat the self as the real subject, and cling instead to the mistaken view that it is essentially a mere substance.

XVII. Dharma

Dharma is the central subject of inquiry in Mīmāṃsā. Jaimini defines Dharma as a **command or injunction which impels men to action** (*chodanālakṣaṇo'rtho dharmah*). It is the supreme duty, the 'ought', the 'categorical imperative'.

Artha and *Kāma*, which deal with ordinary common morality, are learnt through worldly intercourse. But *Dharma* and *Mokṣa*, which deal with true spirituality, are revealed only by the Veda. Dharma is supra-sensible and consists in the commands of the Veda. Action is the final import of the Veda, which commands us to do certain acts and to refrain from doing certain other acts. The authoritativeness of the Veda is supported by social consciousness as well as by individual conscience.

Dharma and Adharma deal with happiness and pain to be enjoyed or suffered in the life beyond. Actions performed here produce an **unseen potency** (*apūrva*) in the soul of the agent, which yields fruit when obstructions are removed and time becomes ripe for its fructification. The *apūrva* is the **link** between the act and its fruit — it is the causal potency (*śakti*) in the act which leads to its fructification.

The Classification of Actions

- **Obligatory** actions (*nitya* and *naimittika*) — actions which **must** be performed, for their violation results in sin, though their performance leads to no additional merit. These are of two kinds: those which must be performed **daily** (*nitya*), like the daily prayers (*sandhyāvandana*), and those which must be performed on **specified occasions** (*naimittika*).
- **Optional** actions (*kāmya*) — actions which **may or may not** be performed; their performance leads to merit, though their non-performance does not lead to sin. E.g., 'he who wants to go to heaven should perform certain sacrifices' (*svargakāmo yajeta*).
- **Prohibited** actions (*pratiṣiddha*) — actions which must **not** be performed; their performance incurs sin and leads to hell, though their non-performance does not, of itself, lead to any special merit.

- **Expiatory acts** (*prāyaścitta*) — acts performed in order to ward off, or at least mitigate, the evil effect of a prohibited action that has already been performed.

From Heaven to Liberation

The earlier Mīmāṃsaka believed only in *dharma* (and not in *mokṣa*), and their ideal was the attainment of heaven (*svarga*). The later Mīmāṃsakas, however, believe in *mokṣa* and substitute the ideal of heaven with that of **liberation** (*apavarga*).

Prabhākara and Kumārila both believe that the goal of human life is liberation, though both conceive it in a **negative** manner, like the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika. The soul is chained to Saṃsāra on account of its association with the body, the senses, the mind, and the understanding; through this association, the soul becomes a knower, an enjoyer, and an agent. This association is due to *karma*, which is the cause of bondage. When the cause is removed, the effect also ceases to exist — so abstention from karma automatically leads to the dissolution of the ‘marriage-tie’ of the soul with the body, the senses, the mind etc., and consequently to the return of the soul to its **pure nature**, as a substance rid of all qualities and modes, including consciousness and bliss. It is a state of freedom from all pain, desire, and consciousness — though Kumārila adds that the soul is here characterised by **potential** consciousness.

Prabhākara and Kumārila both admit that abstention from karma does not mean abstention from **all** karmas, but only from the optional (*kāmya*) and the prohibited (*pratiṣiddha*) kinds. The performance of the former leads to merit and to heaven, while that of the latter leads to demerit and to hell. The seeker for liberation must rise above **both** merit and demerit, above both heaven and hell — but even he should perform the obligatory (*nitya* and *naimittika*) actions enjoined by the Veda.

Prabhākara: Duty for Duty's Sake

Prabhākara believes in ‘**duty for duty's sake**’. Obedience to the Veda is an end in itself, and is of ultimate value (*puruṣārtha*). These actions must be performed in an absolutely **detached** manner, without any consideration of reward, simply because they are the commands of the Veda. Prabhākara believes in the utter supremacy of action, though he admits knowledge also as a means of liberation.

Kumārila: Action as Means, Knowledge as Culmination

Kumārila, by contrast, believes in **psychological hedonism**, and makes the performance of these actions a **means** to realise the ultimate end — liberation — by overcoming past sin and by avoiding the future sin which would otherwise surely result from their neglect. Kumārila believes in **jñāna-karma-samuchchayavāda**, or in a harmonious combination of knowledge and action as the means to liberation, and thus paves the way for Advaita Vedānta. He admits that *upāsanā* (meditation) — itself a kind of action — leads to the knowledge which ultimately leads to liberation.

Kumārila as the Link Between Pūrva and Uttara Mīmāṃsā

Kumārila's view of the self as potential consciousness, his emphasis that action is not an end in itself but only a means to obtain liberation, his acceptance of the view that knowledge of the self born of a true meditative act is the immediate cause of liberation, and his implicit theism — all combine to make him a veritable **link between Prabhākara and Śaṅkara**, between the Pūrva and the Uttara Mīmāṃsās.

It was Kumārila who was actively engaged in a life-long fight against the Buddhists, and if the credit for turning Buddhism out of the land of its birth — apart from the internal weaknesses of Buddhism itself and the changed social, economic and political conditions of the time — goes to a single person, it should go to Kumārila alone. ‘Śaṅkara simply beat the dead horse.’

Kumārila represents the transitional phase from Mīmāṃsā to Vedānta, and is responsible for giving rise to a series of Pre-Śaṅkarite Advaitic teachers of Vedānta, of whom Maṇḍana Miśra was probably one of the last. Kumārila and the Buddhists, like two lions, fought against each other, and the fight led both to bleed to death; Śaṅkara corrected the defects of both and synthesised the merits of both in his Advaitism. This should not mean that Śaṅkara's work was merely eclectic — Śaṅkara, like a true genius, built his immortal system with an originality entirely his own, such that even the dust that passed through his hands became an enchanted powder. What Sharma means is only that Kumārila paved the way, through his voluminous works and his strenuous life-long efforts, for the system of Śaṅkara, and saved him much of the trouble of carrying out the spade-work.

Kumārila himself says that Mīmāṃsā had been misinterpreted by some of his predecessors in a thoroughly empirical and materialistic manner (probably a reference to Bhartṛmitra and Prabhākara), and that his own task was to give it its correct (*āstika*) interpretation. Kumārila accepts the **triple spiritual discipline** of the Vedānta, and points out that Śabara, the great Commentator, had already proved the existence of the eternal self by rational arguments, and that in order to make knowledge of the self firm, one must take recourse to this triple discipline of the Vedānta — which Pārthasārathi explains as study (*śravaṇa*), critical thinking (*manana*), and realization (*nididhyāsana*).

Though, on Pārthasārathi's interpretation, Kumārila does not regard liberation as a state of bliss, it is nonetheless significant that some later writers — for example Nārāyaṇa Bhaṭṭa, the author of the *Mānameyodaya* — believed that Kumārila had in fact advocated a **blissful** liberation. Kumārila himself says, in his *Tantravārtika*: ‘This śāstra called the Veda, which is Sound-Brahman, is supported by the one Supreme Spirit.’

The very first verse of the *Ślokavārtika* is capable of two interpretations. The word ‘*somārdhadhāriṇe*’ in this verse may mean ‘sacrifice equipped with the vessels of *somarasa*’, but it may also mean ‘Lord Śiva, who bears the semi-circular Moon upon His forehead’. The prayer to Lord Śiva is, in fact, unmistakably implied here as well. All this, Sharma concludes, proves his contention that Kumārila is a genuine link between the Pūrva and the Uttara Mīmāṃsās.

Notes compiled from C. D. Sharma, ‘A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy’, Chapter 13 (‘Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā’, pp. 211–238). All positions, arguments, and critical evaluations reproduced here follow Sharma's own exposition and assessment of the Prābhākara, Bhāṭṭa (Kumārila), Naiyāyika, Rāmānuja, and Advaita/Mahāyāna schools on each topic.